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Cultivating listening spaces for civil society: Reorienting public relations amid Hannah Arendt's urgent pluralism

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ABSTRACT

The article explores how the ideas of Hannah Arendt can further public relations' understanding of organizational listening and its role in civil society. We draw on three major theoretical concepts from Arendt and scholars studying her work—plurality, interspaces, and lamp holders—and contextualize them within existing civil society research in public relations. Reading Arendt into organizational listening and civil society literature yields insights for how public relations contributes to the maintenance of structures and spaces for deliberation and civil society. Her theory points toward the concepts of bracketing and unbracketing as ways to enter civic spaces with an awareness of power and identity. As research on organizational listening has yet to fully identify how listening can contribute to supporting representative deliberation in polarized societies, this paper helps to theoretically position listening within civil society and provides initial suggestions as to how civic-minded listening can be incorporated into public relations practices aimed at building community.

Scholarship on organizational listening—as a normative and practical area of public relations theory—has grown in recent years. Listening to actors in an organizational environment connects the public relations function with the crucial work of information gathering, environmental scanning, systematic analysis, and appreciation of external values (e.g., Macnamara, 2016a, 2016b, 2016c; Place, 2019, 2022). In addition to being acknowledged as a means to enhance positive outcomes for organizations, listening is a fundamental part of ethical communication (Coombs & Holladay, 2007) and scholars like Place (2019) and Macnamara (2016a) have pushed for additional research on the subject and greater attention in practice.

While organizational listening frameworks such as Macnamara's "architecture of listening" (2016a, 2016b, 2018b) provide clear, actionable direction for practice, they do not specifically and adequately focus on gaps and blind spots that emerge amid the work of a largely white, affluent class of practitioners and corporate leaders (Varde-man-Winter & Place, 2017). Critical scholarship in organizational listening has begun to address this gap by foregrounding stakeholder experiences and actively seeking the perspectives of underrepresented groups (e.g., Capizzo & Feinman, 2022; O'Neil et al., 2022; Place, 2022). This scholarship has taken hold, not coincidentally, as expectations for corporate and organizational citizenship and contributions to society are

increasing (Hurst & Johnston, 2021; Ihlen & Raknes, 2020; Ingenhoff & Marschlich, 2019; Scherer et al., 2016).

The abstraction of civil society is the primary theoretical context within which public relations scholars have explored how the practice can contribute towards making communities and societies better places in which to live (e.g., Heath, 2006; Sommerfeldt, 2013a; Taylor, 2010). This manuscript further contextualizes organizational listening research—which carries clear potential for democratic and deliberative contributions (Macnamara, 2016b, 2020)—within civil society perspectives, by focusing on the role of listening, including deliberation, in civil society. To help us do so, this paper draws upon Hannah Arendt's political philosophy, in particular the concepts of *plurality*, *interspaces*, and *lamp holders* to augment organizational listening theory and the architecture of listening toward reaching their full potential in contributing to civil society. The writing and philosophy of Hannah Arendt—the German born, U.S.-based political theorist—speaks to the active cultivation of civil society and the civic, discursive spaces necessary for vibrant, functional, and inclusive political discourse to flourish. Arendt's central foci—individual political consciousness and engagement, the need for each of us to be connected to our innate humanity amid the regimentation of modernity, and the dangers of monolithic thinking and regimes—are bracingly urgent in the context of

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political polarization and powerful globalizing capitalist forces. In this way, her work provides a natural bridge between the established architecture of organizational listening (Macnamara, 2016a) and the structures of civil society (Sommerfeldt, 2013a).

As expectations for organizational engagement (particularly contentious issue engagement) increase (Dodd, 2018), organizational listening has the potential to support the functions of social issues management (e.g., Capizzo, 2023; Capizzo & Sommerfeldt, 2021; Coombs & Holladay, 2018) and corporate social advocacy (e.g., Austin et al., 2019; Rim et al., 2020; Waymer & Logan, 2021). It can serve as a way for the public relations function to listen for what may be hard for an organization's leaders to hear (Capizzo & Feinman, 2022; Place, 2022). In these ways, organizations can embrace their responsibilities to contribute to more representative discourse (Weder, 2021) and foster the conditions necessary for a more robust, inclusive civil society to emerge.

Our work, in part, seeks to answer the call issued by Ihlen and Fredriksson (2018) to draw on the work of prominent social theorists, and in so doing provides another “[example] of how public relations also can play other and more positive roles in society, potentially being a driver for positive social change” (p. 2). We create frameworks—to be explored empirically in future research—around civically oriented organizational listening. The next section will introduce organizational listening scholarship in greater detail before turning to the work of Hannah Arendt, and then contextualizing it within public relations scholarship on civil society. The final section synthesizes these findings to augment organizational listening theory and practice in civic contexts, presenting synthesized themes and developing original concepts around listening for civil society in public relations: Listening for deliberative capacity/spaces, listening in genuine light, listening to build social capital, and listening through (Un)Bracketing.

1. Organizational listening

To the best of our knowledge, a succinct definition of organizational listening in public relations research has yet to emerge. However, Macnamara (2016a)—who synthesized a range of definitions across the literature—posited that listening can encompass communicative processes and activities such as: (1) giving recognition to others; (2) acknowledging others' views; (3) paying attention to others; (4) interpreting and constructing meaning from others; (5) trying to understand others' views; (6) giving consideration to others' requests; and (7) responding in an appropriate way after consideration has been given (p. 151). Communication scholarship in listening points toward a variety of skills, resources, and orientations or cultures necessary to listen genuinely (Gregory, 2015; Gregory & Halff, 2020; Husband, 2009; Macnamara, 2018b; Place, 2019; Wolvin, 2010). Having listening-oriented policies, open systems, and structures for systematically gathering and distilling listening insights allows organizations to reap these benefits (Capizzo & Feinman, 2022; Dreher, 2009; Macnamara, 2016b, 2018b; Gregory & Macnamara, 2019; Macnamara & Gregory, 2018; Place, 2019).

As perhaps the largest listening inquiry in public relations to date, Macnamara's (2016a, 2016b) Organizational Listening Project synthesized interdisciplinary scholarship on listening from communication, management, customer service, and public communication research alongside practitioner interviews to understand both the best practices and the gaps or opportunities for organizations to listen more effectively, more openly, and more authentically. It articulated an architecture of listening—such as a listening culture, listening-oriented policies, open systems, and listening skills (Macnamara, 2016a, 2016b)—which serve as guideposts for further research as well as pillars for listening in practice. The study found that many of the functional steps toward improving listening are easily achievable for organizations but often not addressed. Genuine listening also opens organizations up to risk and expectations for change, and some organizations have consciously

chosen to avoid such challenges. At its center, the project reminded scholars and practitioners in public relations of the imperative to listen first and listen more often than we speak—despite training and professional guidelines that emphasize the speaking and information dissemination aspects of professional communication. Not only do these choices have implications for organizational interests, organizational stakeholders, and community wellbeing, but they impact the ability of organizations to make substantive democratic and deliberative contributions (Capizzo & Feinman, 2022; Macnamara, 2020).

Recent research in organizational listening has begun to add critical values to this trajectory. As societal expectations for social issues engagement continue to rise (i.e., Capizzo, 2023; Coombs & Holladay, 2018; Dodd, 2018), public relations has the potential to galvanize advocacy (Edrington, 2022; Madden & Alt, 2021; Waymer & Logan, 2021). In such contexts, critically centered organizational listening allows organizations to see richer and more nuanced issue contexts, and to better understand the complex ecosystems of stakeholders and community members that they inhabit. It may help organizations overcome “an underlying myopic focus on organizational priorities” (Capizzo & Feinman, 2022, p. 2), and become more aware of power imbalances among stakeholders that influence organizational decision making (Place, 2022).

At the practitioner level, Place's (2022) intersectional listening approach emphasizes practitioner reflexivity, preparation prior to engagement, empathy, and active seeking of perspectives from “publics who are not present at or left out of dialogue, research, planning, or strategizing” (p. 16). At a community level, it requires deliberately inclusive coalition building and partnerships among diverse publics, community groups, and government entities. Place's perspective emphasizes that genuine listening is not a one-time affair, but is best facilitated through long-term partnerships, negotiations, and engagement. In a democratic context, particularly amid political polarization, Capizzo and Feinman (2022) pointed to pluralistic engagement, reflective processes, and a social problem-solving focus, as well as adopting an “Other” orientation to listen across difference (Place & Ciszek, 2021).

The aforementioned works have begun the process of connecting organizational listening theory to its full civic potential. Taken together, these studies have articulated the ways in which the public relations function can use listening to reorient organizations to better understand their civic and community contexts and respond to evolving societal norms and needs. Using the political theory of Hannah Arendt as a guide, the next section brings organizational listening more closely into conversation with the role and potential of public relations in strengthening civil society.

2. Arendt and civil society

Hannah Arendt (1906–1975), political theorist, refugee, reporter, and witness to some of the greatest horrors of the 20th century, created through her decades of writing a roadmap (and a plea) for a functioning, humane, deliberative society amid the chaos and inhumanity of modernity (Young-Bruehl, 2004). The modern world, emerging in the late 19th and early 20th centuries, reflected a focus on production, efficiency, scale, and a mechanization of many parts of human life. Her work, including *The origins of totalitarianism* (Arendt (1951), *The human condition* (1958), and *On revolution* (Arendt (1963b/2006b))), pushed back by presenting a stark perspective on the greatest tensions facing individuals in modern society as well as the societies themselves—alienation and commonality, action and contemplation, public and private domains, individuality and plurality, as well as hope and false optimism (Arnett, 2013). She points toward the deep individual and group dangers of living as an unreflective banality, or existing in complex societies without reflecting on the consequences of our individual actions (Arendt, 1963a). Living together and creating successful shared governance of democratic societies requires conscious effort, engagement, listening, and reflecting. As the work of other major social

theorists has been used to inform public relations theory, scholarship, and practice (e.g., Edwards, 2018; Holmström, 2018; Luoma-aho, 2018), Arendt provides new direction and insight for understanding public relations and its relationship with democratic society.

Arendt only briefly (and derisively) addressed the role of professional communicators in these processes—in *Crisis of the republic*, for example, she describes “the antics of consumer society and the public-relations managers who cater to it” (Arendt, 1972, p. 9). Public relations scholars have similarly argued that the additional power given to communicators in deliberative societies merits significant additional responsibility (e.g., Gregory, 2015; Heath & Waymer, 2017; Holmström, 2005; Macnamara, 2016b). Along the same lines, civic responsibilities and expectations for organizations, and particularly for large, global corporations, have continued to increase amid fractured transnational corporate governance efforts (Dawkins, 2021; Koya et al., 2021; Palazzo & Scherer, 2006). In a communicative context, Arnett (2013) pointed out Arendt’s recurring metaphor of light and darkness—and of the dangers of false light. This included the ways in which modernity (and its values of efficiency, logic, and scale) tend to permeate the conversations in civic deliberation at the expense of individual human concerns and experiences. In public relations, this same impulse is reflected in the paradox of the positive (Heath & Waymer, 2009), which will be discussed in the next section.

Few scholars in public relations have integrated Arendt’s thought into their work, and those that have done so mention her only in passing (e.g., Bourne, 2019; Davidson, 2016; Ni & Kim, 2009; Roper & Hurst, 2019). A notable exception is Anne Cronin’s (2018) book, *Public relations capitalism: Promotional culture, publics and commercial democracy*, which examines Arendt’s understanding of the social contract and its implications for promotional industries and what Cronin termed *commercial democracy*. In Cronin’s understanding, the loss of societal trust has opened the door for public relations—for better or worse—to fill a communicative void: “Shifts in people’s perception and trust of institutions and government, alongside public dislike and distrust of marketing and advertising messages, have set the scene for PR’s growth” (p. 43). Thus, the social promises embedded in the work of public relations, mediating the relationships among organizations and their stakeholders, mirror democratic practices and “operate as vernacular forms of democracy” (p. 44), recentring social order in corporate-controlled spaces. Breaking brand promises damages reputation with communities, publics, and stakeholders. Cronin also noted that Arendt saw more nuance than most political theorists around the ideas of lying and imagination in politics—foreshadowing a post-truth political climate, writing:

Imagination and lying are intertwined as fundamental human characteristics and act as the very site of politics. In my argument, PR’s capacity to both *manage truths* and *broker new forms of promise* place PR in a privileged position in today’s new sociopolitical context. (p. 113)

Building on Arnett’s (2013) work in rhetoric and communication, Capizzo and Feinman (2022), delved into Arendt’s central, recurring ideas and themes, including pluralism, public and private spaces, otherness and alienation, and forgiveness. This paper extends their work by examining three further themes from Arendt and those building on her thinking: Plurality, interspaces, and (using Arnett’s synthesis) lamp holders, or those using communication to illuminate reality and guard against “artificial light” (2013, p. 242)—the false, dehumanizing logics and narratives of modernity. We review each of these concepts in detail before turning to a discussion of how they might be added to public relations’ consideration of fostering and maintaining a civil society.

2.1. Plurality: beyond pluralism

As offered by Grunig (2000), the idea of pluralism “means that democracy functions as a free marketplace of ideas in which every

individual, or every individual organization, is free to engage in advocacy to further its interests in competition with others” (p. 38). Foundational (if controversial) ideas in public relations, such as two-way symmetrical communication, are grounded in the notion of a pluralistic society, wherein all social actors have the access and ability to contribute to public discussions. However, most critical scholars accept that pluralism does not, and has not, truly existed in society (L’Etang, 2005). Beyond mere pluralism, or an acceptance of the validity of a variety of different perspectives, opinions, and values, Arendt’s concept of *plurality* speaks to a more fundamental aspect of the relationship between our individual, discrete humanity and the importance of its representation as part of democratic spaces (Arnett, 2013). Arendt (1958) described plurality as “the condition—not only the *conditio sine qua non*, but the *conditio per quam*—of all political life” (p. 7)—the inherent condition of individual difference is, in essence, the cause of our social or political lives. The reality of being separate individuals living among others makes our lives inextricable from plurality. Additionally, Arendt saw our own individual and internal conflicts, contradictions, and nuances as evidence for a plurality of or within the self. In her understanding, there is “plurality inherent in every human being” (2005, p. 21) as well as in the distinctness and separateness of every individual human being:

In other words, political freedom is possible only in the sphere of human plurality, and on the premise that this sphere is not simply an extension of the dual I-and-myself to a plural We. Action, in which a We is always engaged in changing our common world, stands in the sharpest possible opposition to the solitary business of thought, which operates in a dialogue between me and myself. (Arendt, 1978, p. 200)

The ability to express our individual plurality is, in essence, freedom. For Arendt, this tension between personal freedom and a shared world is the nature of politics.

Such personal freedom does not require (and would also not functionally condone) absolute sovereignty for every individual, but the ability to have a domain of individuality as well as shared public space of peers (Arendt, 2005). She elaborated that individual freedom is not,

something that can be achieved by political means. It is rather the substance and meaning of all things political. In this sense, politics and freedom are identical, and wherever this kind of freedom does not exist, there is no political space in the true sense. (p. 129)

Thus, our ability to fully understand and share our individual and organizational identities and perspectives is central to healthy political life. This, in turn, requires spaces and places for both private or internal reflection as well as public discussion and discourse (Roberts-Miller, 2002). It involves internal understanding, whether within one person or among those in an organization, as well as an awareness and an acceptance of others with differing views and experiences.

Otherness is “an important aspect of plurality” (Arendt, 1958, p. 176) in that the acknowledgement and acceptance of the separate individual identities of those who are not ourselves creates distance and distinctness. The processes of politics are, quite literally, the tussling of “others” coming together in communal spaces around shared issues:

The calamities of action all arise from the human condition of plurality, which is the condition *sine qua non* for that space of appearance which is the public realm. Hence the attempt to do away with this plurality is always tantamount to the abolition of the public realm itself. (Arendt, 1958, p. 220)

Thus, Arendt connected the importance of plurality in political life to the maintenance and care for the spaces of public engagement or appearance—the interspaces that allow for civic deliberation to occur.

2.2. Interspaces in civic deliberation

Arendt's life and thought was undoubtedly influenced by the rise of totalitarianism in Europe and the closing of public space, public debate, and public tolerance. She explains that societies need to care for the interspaces that protect social and civic bonds, as well as individual autonomy and responsibility (Arnett, 2013). Much of her work in political theory reflects the need for individuals and systems to protect individual autonomy, and allow for the time, space, and freedom for vigorous debate and deliberation. In this same vein, "Arendt suggests that totalitarianism finds a foothold when the public arena is no longer a place of freedom" (Arnett, 2013, p. 55). Thus, cultivation and protection of productive, inclusive democratic spaces and norms is crucial to functioning democracy and civil society. She used the term "interspaces" directly as part of her work, *Men in dark times* (Arendt, 1968), a book that profiles people who created hope amid turmoil and destruction. She positioned these individuals as beacons able to lead communities and societies toward collective understanding. Without the maintenance of individual differences and perspectives, societies would not be recognizable:

Out of many opinions one would emerge, as though not men in their infinite plurality but man in the singular, one species and its exemplars, were to inhabit the earth. Should that happen, the world, which can form only in the interspaces between men in all their variety, would vanish altogether. (p. 31)

Thus, the shared world created among human beings would essentially cease to exist without the ability to nurture and share our individual identities and experiences with each other. The profiles in this book emphasized the value of leading through genuine belief, empathy, and advocacy rather than through power. Their stories demonstrated the galvanization and catalyzation of movements through narrative and activism—including writers and artists including Bertolt Brecht and Gotthold Ephraim Lessing as well as revolutionaries and reformers such as Rosa Luxemburg and Angelo Giuseppe Roncalli (better known as Pope John XXIII). These individuals did not dictate, but actively and publicly cultivated discussion around the issues important to them. They effectively bridged private beliefs and public discourse. In each case they found or made space for these ideas in public consciousness.

In Arendt's terms, those making the greatest contributions to society were living and working in the interspaces between and the differentiation among people and ideas in public life and deliberation. These spaces were vital to the ability of leaders, even under difficult circumstances, to make change in their communities (or for the futures of those communities), and for the members of those communities. The existence of such spaces is not an accident, and they are crucial to societies being able to make reasonable accommodations for their citizens: "The gardening of the human condition rests with protected interspaces" (Arnett, 2013, p. 195). Tending to them is an ongoing act. In societies with precarious interspaces—such as Brecht's Weimar-era Germany—the act of generating and sharing politicized speech is risk laden:

[Poets] cannot bear the same burden of responsibility as ordinary mortals; they need a measure of remoteness, and yet would not be worth their salt if they were not forever tempted to exchange this remoteness for being just like everybody else. On this attempt Brecht staked his life and his art as few poets had ever done; it led him into triumph and disaster. (Arendt, 1968, p. 247)

Interspaces may be dangerous places for those whom, out of necessity, fight for their survival and continued cultivation. But it is these acts of risk-taking that create illumination, rather than the false light of efficient, practical, unreflective modernity (Arnett, 2013). Escaping the trap of modernity rests in engagement and participation in civic life: "Liberation requires participating in the public domain, a place respectful of interspaces and the distance between persons and ever so distrustful of modernity's attempt to disallow the traditions of Others"

(pp. 258–259). Who does Arendt see as providing hope and genuine light in times of darkness? Those who do not blithely allow modernity to sweep them (and others) away. Individuals that are willing to engage with the challenges around them, listen to others, reflect, and act.

2.3. Communicators as lamp holders

In reflecting back on her most widely read work, *Eichmann in Jerusalem: A report on the banality of evil* (1963a), Arendt (1971) wrote of Adolf Eichmann (a Nazi leader and major figure in organizing the logistics of the Holocaust) that his "total absence of thinking attracted my interest. Is evil-doing, not just the sins of omission, but the sins of commission, possible in the sense not merely 'base motives' (as the law calls it) but of any motives at all?" (p. 418). For Arendt, Eichmann represented the ultimate dangers of a total lack of personal reflection and individual responsibility. Her fear for the safety and sustainability of democratic society amid the terror demonstrated in World War II—specifically, the murderous rise of fascism and totalitarianism as a response to societies and economies that were becoming increasingly complex and difficult to manage—came from a deep distrust of modernity, of efficiency, and of the mechanization and compartmentalization of human beings and human thought. Banality, mundaneness, and normalcy of reprehensible actions were enabled by the ease with which individuals could disengage their individual identities from the seemingly distant bureaucratic machines in which they worked.

Thus, Arendt's heroes and heroines reflect those who reject false light—the seeming ease of unreflective and unthoughtful ways of going about our daily lives (Arnett, 2013). By meeting, engaging, and working to understand others in public space, these heroes create genuine hope rather than false or artificial light—they are building resilience, activism, and spaces for survival and thriving through art and activism rather than through ungrounded optimism or faith in modernity. It is through knowing others, forgiveness, and public friendship that difference is acknowledged and valued (Arendt, 1968). This fully actualized citizenship comes through an understanding of the world grounded not just in individual opinions and experiences, but through entering public spaces and understanding the perspectives of others (Arendt, 1961/1977).

Arnett's (2013) deep synthesis of Arendt's work points toward a specific role for communication in maintaining the societal bonds and individual responsibilities of civil society, that of *lamp holders*:

Lamp holders remind us that in accepting the responsibility to illuminate the public domain, they protect the public domain as a place of welcome with interspaces and differences among persons. They find meaning in responsibility and in the burden of doing tasks for the health of the public domain. (p. 262)

These individuals may or may not consider themselves professional communicators, but certainly reflect a care for and commitment to functional communication in public spaces. By contrast, "a place illuminated by too much artificial light can make it impossible for the background of darkness to permit us to see the light before our own eyes" (p. 118). For public relations theory, this false light is reflected in our *paradox of the positive* (e.g., Heath & Waymer, 2009; Johnston et al., 2020; Waymer & Heath, 2016, 2021), the negative aspects and implications of the sometimes relentlessly optimistic framing of issues that characterizes a not-insignificant part of modern public relations work. As Stoker (2014) explained,

organizations often ignore the possibility that contradictory forces exist simultaneously and focusing on the most positive of the opposing elements is akin to taking off one's watch while falling off a building and assuming that because the watch is at rest, one is at rest. (p. 347)

The world presented by some public relations practices and practitioners is not reality and represents what Arendt might see as a false light

in otherwise dark circumstances.

Individual citizenship and being in the world requires deliberation and thoughtful action (Arendt, 1958). As public communicators, public relations professionals have the opportunity to play an even more crucial and functional role in cultivating and illuminating spaces for functional deliberation. This is added professional and social responsibility as, “holding a lamp for another is a burden” (Arnett, 2013, p. 262). But it is difficult to consider Arendt without seeing the gravity of the opportunity that is missed by not holding individual communicators, the public relations function in organizations, and the public relations profession to higher standards and broader conceptions of citizenship and discursive responsibility.

Having now relayed three major concepts from Arendt we believe are useful to the integration of her thought into public relations’ theoretical treatments of civil society, we now turn to an explication of that concept. Public relations has been understood as capable of contributing to community-building efforts (Valentini et al., 2012) and strengthening civil society (Taylor, 2010; Sommerfeldt, 2013a). This section provides an overview of this work before synthesizing it with the concepts from Arendt and critical listening approaches to build toward a civic-minded organizational listening framework..

3. Civil society and the public sphere

Scholars have recently begun to explore the potential contributions of public relations to civil society (Sommerfeldt, 2013a; Taylor, 2010; Taylor & Sommerfeldt, 2021). The notion of civil society is centuries old, and with even older connections to ancient theories of democracy. In his analysis of American culture nearly 200 years ago, Alexis de Tocqueville (1835/2003) observed high levels of participation in voluntary associations— independent of the state—by the American citizenry. Such engagement in civic activity struck de Tocqueville as a mainstay of the budding democratic culture and rising economic vigor of the young American nation. Through Tocqueville and other theorists such as Hegel (1820/1974) and Habermas (1981), the concept of civil society entered social theory as a way to describe the capacity of a community to organize itself without the direction or intervention of the state (Calhoun, 1993; Hauser, 1998). In other words, the people, organizations, and systems of relationships that comprise civil society exist independently and freely operate in a realm outside of government.

Theories of civil society have maintained that a successfully functioning democracy requires a set of autonomous organizations and institutions that work to check the power of the state and build social infrastructure (Gibson, 2001; Hauser, 1998). Civil society is enhanced by the levels of individual participation in civic organizations and

political engagement (Putnam, 2000). Civil society has thus been perceived by many scholars as an essential precondition of successful democratization and sustaining democratic institutions (Gibson, 2001; Taylor, 2010; Sommerfeldt, 2013a). These views match Arendt’s own interpretation of a civil society, which could be summarized as “a sphere of associations institutionalized by the voluntary engagement of active citizens” (Yildirim, 2014, p. 880).

Sommerfeldt (2013a) explained the connection between civil society and public sphere theory—which has more direct implications for our consideration of listening herein. Civil society is the ground from which public spheres of deliberation take root and emerge. Downey and Fenton (2003) observed that civil society is a mediating space in pluralistic democracies, “a place where individuals and groups are free to form organizations that function independently and that can mediate between citizens and the state—the place where autonomous public spheres reside” (p. 190). When a community has the requisite level of engagement on matters of public concern, public spheres of discussion are more likely to emerge, flourish, and become the space in which ideas are heard, deliberated, and where the best ideas win out.

Public relations scholars have turned to civil society theory—alongside related perspectives like Fully Functioning Society Theory (Aghazadeh, 2022; Heath, 2006)—as a mechanism for looking beyond organizational interests to understand how the practice can contribute towards making communities and societies a better place in which to live, and in which organizations reap environmental benefits. Scholars have connected civil society theory to that of relationship management (Ledingham & Bruning, 2000) and organization-public relationships, or OPRs (e.g., Sommerfeldt, 2013b). In blending these theories, scholars have argued that public relations practice can contribute to relationship maintenance among civil society actors such as NGOs that are central to the continued vitality of civil society movements and the accomplishment of goals (Taylor, 2010). These relationships provide individual civil society actors with social capital—the resources that help organizations to accomplish goals that would not be as easily accomplished without such relationships (Sommerfeldt & Taylor, 2011).

3.1. Bracketing and listening in civil society

But where is the opening for deeper consideration of listening in this theoretic space? Habermas’ account of the bourgeois public sphere rested on the ideal of pluralism and open access—though that ideal has been heavily contested (cf. Fraser, 1990). In Habermas’ conceptualization, for the public sphere to function as it should—to be the place in which ideas were examined on their own merits—the interlocutor of those ideas should be considered as a peer, no matter their social or economic status. As Fraser described it, Habermas’ “public sphere requires bracketing inequalities of status” (p. 63). The ability for people to freely debate is created when “egalitarian arenas of interaction are created by a systematic bracketing of inequality” (Cassegård, 2014, p. 692). As Cassegård further explained:

Publics, in other words, arise when participants systematically disregard real differences and relations of dependency in order to create a semblance of equality between participants. In the other conception, it is rather by contestation, by openly challenging exclusion and inequality, that genuine publicness can occur. (p. 692)

Cassegård also remarked on the need for interaction in local, physical spaces to accomplish true contestation and bracketing, rather than “disembodied interaction” (p. 692).

At the same time, Fraser’s (1990) widely cited criticisms of Habermas’ conceptualization of the public sphere argued that disadvantaged groups like women, people of LGBTQ identities, and ethnic minorities have created subaltern counterpublics. Fraser argued the ability to bracket social inequalities and status differentials is near impossible, and that subaltern groups therefore employ a strategy of “unbracketing”—making inequality visible instead of pretending it does not exist.

Table 1
Arendt’s themes for public relations theory.

Arendt’s Themes	Connections to Public Relations Theory and Organizational Listening	Definitions
Interspaces (Arendt, 1968)	Deliberative spaces (Edwards, 2016); Democratic listening (Macnamara, 2020)	Interspaces—the buffers among public and private spaces for reflection and deliberation—must be cultivated and maintained for individuals to be able to make their full contributions to civil and deliberative society.
Lamp Holders (Arnett, 2013)	Paradox of the positive (Heath & Waymer, 2009; Waymer & Heath, 2021); Critical civic listening (Capizzo & Feinman, 2022)	Lamp holders provide genuine illumination and hope in times of darkness, while avoiding false light.
Plurality (Arendt, 1958)	Dialogue (Kent & Taylor, 2002; Lane, 2020; Paquette et al., 2015) Intersectional listening (Place, 2022)	Plurality reflects the essential differences among individual people that contribute to both shared societal success and community conflict.

Cassegård (2014) described Fraser’s unbracketing as “a polemical visibilization of inequality which at the same time functions as an *accusation* against existing forms of the public sphere and which disrupts and challenges the bracketing on which it is constituted” (p. 695).

While public relations role in a fully-functioning civil society has been extensively discussed (i.e. Heath, 2006; Sommerfeldt, 2013a; Taylor, 2010), the notion of bracketing—and its counterpart, unbracketing—remains an unaddressed concept in our literature. That said, we believe it to have strong linkages to both Arendt’s political philosophy as well as relevant perspectives on organizational listening. We unpack the implications of the previously introduced concepts in the sections that follow.

4. Discussion and implications

Having reviewed three concepts central to Arendt’s thought and juxtaposed them with literature in civil society and organizational listening for public relations, the discussion synthesizes three central themes for theory and practice: (1) voice and visibility: (un)bracketing, listening, and plurality; (2) listening together: civil society, interspaces, and deliberative systems; and (3) holding lamps: social capital, paradoxes, and genuine light. Taken together, they represent the potential for organizational listening to help organizations make more meaningful contributions to civil society through a deepening of the societal obligations of the profession. Collectively, we refer to this framework as civic-minded organizational listening.

4.1. Voice and visibility: (Un)bracketing, listening, and plurality

Perhaps the first area in which there is significant overlap and insight to be gained from Arendt’s work is reflecting on the notion of bracketing and its alignment with her writings on plurality. We find opportunities for developing listening approaches in public relations through both the bracketing and unbracketing approaches. Bracketing presumes that one considers another discussant in public spaces to be an equal and will therefore give their words and ideas full consideration. Organizational listening has this potential, particularly when understood with an emphasis on intersectional identities (Place, 2022). Similarly, scholars of the dialogic theory tradition (e.g., Kent & Taylor, 2002; Paquette et al., 2015) would likewise maintain that effective communication requires the elevation of one’s communication partner to that of an equal. Genuine dialogue sees communication partners as equals (I-Thou), rather than as mere recipients of persuasive messages (I-It) (Sommerfeldt & Yang, 2018). Botan (1997) explained that dialogue “elevates publics to the status of communication equal with the organization” (p. 196). Such a perspective, which relies heavily on Kantian deontological ethics (cf. Paquette et al., 2015), would seemingly insist that status differentials be bracketed to accommodate both the ethical intent of dialogue as well as following the structural procedures to enact it (cf. Lane, 2020).

However, in certain situations, bracketing may not be necessary, nor may it be ethically appropriate for organizations to adopt. As discussed above, for some marginalized publics, bracketing is an impossibility, as their very existence is coalesced around their status differential. Indeed, the public relations literature categorizes publics as groups of individuals around shared recognition of a problem. That problem may be more or less externalized or internalized—that is, may arise from conflicts with an organization or may come from the internal recognition that one’s marginalized status is a problem created by others (Sommerfeldt & Iannaccone, 2023). Moreover, membership in a disadvantaged group means that shared experiences may not need to be bracketed among those of that group (Cassegård, 2014).

Arendt (1968) recognized the importance of protecting both private and public spaces—providing the interspaces that allow for identity-laden decisions of bracketing to be choices rather than obligations to enter certain spaces of discourse. Scholars have recently called

Table 2
Civic-minded organizational listening for civil society in public relations.

Concept	Definition	Supporting Literature
Listening for deliberative capacity/ spaces	Public relations can be a productive contributor to reflective, substantive organizational contributions to democratic and civic discourse. Organizational listening provides a conduit to holistic, empathetic engagement that increases the number and capacity of such spaces.	Arendt, 1958, 1963a, 1968; Capizzo & Feinman, 2022; Habermas, 1996; Edwards, 2016; Macnamara, 2018a, 2020; Ramsey, 2016; Rostboll, 2008; Sommerfeldt, 2013a
Listening in genuine light	Public relations has a professional and civic obligation to avoid falsely positive framing that obscures inequity and power differentials. Organizational listening provides intersectional and critical tools for practitioners to understand and communicate amid complex community structures.	Arendt, 1968; Arnett, 2013; Capizzo & Feinman, 2022; Fraser, 1990; Heath & Waymer, 2009; Johnston et al., 2020; Place, 2022; Stoker, 2014; Waymer & Heath, 2016, 2021
Listening to build social capital	Public relations builds community, civic, and social bonds, contributing to institutional trust. Organizational listening provides the knowledge needed to bridge social gaps, genuinely see underrepresented (and under-connected) community members, and strengthen civic ties.	Hurst & Johnston, 2021; Luoma-aho, 2018; Macnamara & Gregory, 2018; Putnam, 1993, 2000; Taylor, 2000, 2010; Valentini et al., 2012
Listening through (Un)Bracketing	Public relations contributes to internal and external debate within and among organizations, helping them enter conversations and conflicts with an awareness of power differentials. Organizational listening provides structure for bracketing/unbracketing difference and identity toward ethical collaboration.	Arendt, 1958; Botan, 1997; Cassegård, 2014; Lane, 2020; Place & Ciszek, 2021; Place, 2022; Roberts-Miller, 2002; Yildirim, 2014

for practices that ethically engage across difference, acknowledging that difference, and engaging with the intent to empower and elevate marginalized voices (Place & Ciszek, 2021). Place and Ciszek, for instance, raised the example of communicating with marginalized LGBT groups—noting that deontological ethics as well as feminist ethics, postmodern ethics, and ethics of care may be appropriate to utilize as a framework in such situations. The former aligns with more traditional approaches to dialogue (Paquette et al., 2015) while the latter emphasizes the recognition of structural and symbolic power and their unavoidable influence on communication. Communicating amid plurality requires us to recognize the humanity of others (Arendt, 1958), but it does not require passivity or consensus: “Civil society is not a site devoid of disagreement or conflict; rather, it is very often a locale of conflict with dissenting opinions making continued appearances” (Yildirim, 2014, p. 876).

For public relations to effectively contribute to civil society, organizations must adopt listening practices that elevate publics to the status of a communication equal (bracketing), but also embrace the plurality of perspectives and acknowledge difference and power imbalances. Unbracketing, aligned with Arendt’s conception of plurality, emphasizes the need for organizations and individuals to (1) reflect, consider, and thoughtfully debate positions or policies on topics that matter (e.g.,

Roberts-Miller, 2002); (2) to share and understand these positions relative to other social actors in their midst; and (3) to engage in and manage the unavoidable conflicts that arise from the nature of difference among entities working to live together. As Arendt described, such steps rely on both the mutual respect necessary for meeting other human beings in public spaces as well as the space and freedom to maintain individuality. Bracketing and unbracketing allow for the expression of these dichotomies and provide guidance for activists as well as public relations professionals working with an awareness of power inequities. Most importantly, organizations must enter public conversations first as listeners, and do the reflective, deliberative work needed for just and substantive civic contributions.

4.2. *Listening together: civil society, interspaces, and deliberative systems*

A primary motive for public relations scholars exploring the theoretic and practical contributions of the discipline to a fully functioning civil society is, teleologically, how the practice can benefit deliberation and secure democratic institutions (Heath, 2006; Sommerfeldt, 2013a). The participation in deliberation through advocacy is essential to public relations' role, ensuring organizations' voices are heard in the "wrangle" of the marketplace of ideas (Heath, 2006). But to fully engage in deliberation with others, and to ensure that deliberation and resulting public spheres support a robust democracy, Dobson (2014) argued that citizens must follow the rules of good listening, and the need to "listen out" for new or marginalized voices—as is similarly emphasized in Arendt's plurality (Capizzo & Feinman, 2022). Macnamara (2016a) explained how American philosopher John Dewey positioned human society as composed through communication in the dialogic sense, as positioned by theorists like Bakhtin (1981) and Buber (1958). As Arendt understood, people must be able to express their views and experiences as well as listening to others (Arendt, 1958). Social actors need the spaces to perform both reflective and discursive work to fully participate in political life. For the public sphere and civil society to function effectively, one must want to know what others want to say (Gadamer, 1989).

Indeed, listening to the ideas and concerns of others is a mainstay of several versions of deliberative theories of democracy, to which civil society and public sphere theories are closely related. In Habermas's view (1996), citizens do not simply put ideas out for vetting but have reciprocal discussion with others. Dryzek (2000), who was heavily influenced by Habermas, argued that "effective listening has to be central to any discursive democracy" (p. 149), and Rostboll's (2008) theory of deliberative freedom suggested that what "matters for success of deliberation in the first phase is that people are willing to show up and communicate with each other, to speak their minds, and listen to each other" (p. 121). Arendt understood that the discursive spaces necessary should not be taken for granted: That tending and care are needed to ensure that these are spaces of access, representation, and voice—and organizations play a central role in this ongoing work (Arnett, 2013).

There are multiple perspectives through which public relations practices and the public relations function can contribute to democratic systems. In contrast to a Habermasian, rational-critical model of deliberation that sees public relations as harming the integrity of civic systems and processes (cf. Habermas, 1989, 1992), scholars in management and public relations have pointed to the value of organizational engagement in constructive conflict around societal challenges (e.g., Ciszek & Logan, 2018; Davidson, 2016; Dawkins, 2021; Edwards, 2016; Palazzo & Scherer, 2006; Ramsey, 2016). Edwards (2016) theorized public relations as having neutral, negative, or potentially positive contributions to deliberative systems in democratic societies—as a tool that can be used for narrow corporate or organizational interests or for activism, social change, and societal benefit. Functionally, public relations can "contribute to deliberation by ensuring that adequate information about government practice and policy is available for publics to make informed choices about their political support and

participation" (p. 63). It can also support both improved representation for groups that may be historically or traditionally underrepresented in democratic processes (Weder, 2021) and break or reframe obstructive or restrictive consensus situations in favor of more productive, agonistic debate (Davidson, 2016; Ramsey, 2016). This is due, in part, to the ways in which thoughtful, listening-oriented public relations practices can contribute to (and, potentially, expand) spaces for deliberation (Edwards, 2016).

Granted, most public relations is still strategically practiced on behalf of organizational actors with their own interests to be advanced (Ihlen, 2005; Sommerfeldt, 2013a). But deeper integration of civic-minded organizational listening into public relations practices can support deliberative systems as reflecting the realistic, combative, interest-oriented discourse of democratic politics, with public relations acting as "an indispensable element in the complex processes of production, circulation, and uptake of deliberative debates" (Edwards, 2016, p. 66). Applying Arendt's interspaces to civil society emphasizes the central role organizations and the public relations function play in making contributions to a deliberative society. They achieve this through (1) active cultivation of productive, representative deliberative spaces, (2) deliberative engagement and contributions that respect the contributions of others—particularly with an awareness to power imbalances, and (3) adding to the awareness of public relations' professional responsibility to strengthen deliberative capacity.

4.3. *Holding lamps: social capital, paradoxes, and genuine light*

We are not the first to emphasize the need for public relations professionals to be stewards of discourse and organizational legitimacy as well as mindful of the practice's role in buttressing social and democratic norms (e.g., Capizzo, 2018; Heath et al., 2013; Taylor, 2010). The full implications of the paradox of the positive invite the public relations practice to center not only on ethical advocacy, but on reasonable (not overly optimistic) interpretations and presentations of reality (Waymer & Heath, 2021). Practitioners must also listen in light of dissensus and conflict in order to fully grasp the perspectives of stakeholders (Capizzo & Feinman, 2022). By listening for what may be hard to hear, the public relations function and the profession have the potential to create genuine light rather than false light. An example can be clearly seen in the aftermath of George Floyd's murder in Minneapolis in 2020, which sparked protests worldwide for racial justice and against police violence. Many U.S.-based organizations made public statements of support for the Black Lives Matter movement in the midst of these powerful events, most doing so without truly listening to internal (and proximate external) stakeholders and addressing issues of racial inequity within their own organizational practices (Capizzo & Harrison, 2023; Dowell & Jackson, 2020). In doing so, they used their communications to shine false light on the issue, which, in the long term, undermines public and social trust in institutions—pillars of civil society—rather than doing the more challenging work of admitting their own shortcomings and working to resolve them.

Organizations need not be perfect or act perfectly to create hope amid conflict, but their words and actions should be genuine, particularly in difficult circumstances (e.g., Ciszek & Logan, 2018; Logan, 2016; Waymer & Logan, 2021). This genuineness in action must be drawn from an openness to non-organizational perspectives and an awareness of power inequities that can be built through organizational listening (Place, 2022). Facing societal challenges requires a collective acceptance of the inevitability of dissensus and conflict (Capizzo & Sommerfeldt, 2021; Ciszek, 2016; Kennedy & Sommerfeldt, 2015), but also the acknowledgment of a shared social or communal project (Valentini et al., 2012). It requires different ways of considering how to measure the impact of public relations beyond the organizational level and beyond the trope of consensus (Capizzo, 2022). The U.S. has historically been a bastion of civic-minded individuals and robust communal associations (Tocqueville, 1835/2003), but individuals have more recently

been less likely to form such bonds (Putnam, 2000) despite their individual or organizational benefits—not to mention their value to communities and society (Putnam, 2000). Luoma-aho (2018) linked the continued or repeating positive experiences of working together with others in the community as building: first, an expectation of interpersonal trust and a willingness to work together and, eventually, a generalized trust in others. A commitment to organizational listening, particularly with a critical lens (Capizzo & Feinman, 2022; Place, 2022), may help organizations to bridge existing gaps in knowledge, perspective, and collective empathy with publics and stakeholders that can build or rebuild community ties.

Of course, negative feedback cycles can also occur, lowering societal trust due to individual and collective poor experiences. Particularly in the darkest times—within which Arnett (2013) emphasized that Arendt framed her work—organizations and the public relations function have a central role to play in reinforcing the positive feedback loop of social trust. Thus, the public relations function has civic obligations to (1) ensure transparency and clarity in often convoluted issue communication, (2) promote realistic discourse rather than unreasonably positive contributions (e.g., Waymer & Heath, 2021), and (3) listen toward fostering relationships among societal actors that grow trust and build social capital.

4.4. Limitations and future directions

While this research takes an important step toward connecting civil society and organizational listening, there is significant potential for further conceptual, theoretical, and empirical exploration. This includes additional conceptual development at the societal level of organizational listening scholarship, following Place (2022), as well as to add additional concrete practical and ethical connections. For example, how does a civic listening approach augment existing public relations professional and ethical frameworks? Theoretically, civic listening has additional potential for connection with deliberative systems (Edwards, 2016) and—given the critical nature of Arendt's work—with scholarship on intersectionality, race, and social justice (e.g., Logan, 2019, 2021; Logan & Ciszek, 2021; Vardeman-Winter & Tindall, 2010). Future empirical scholarship could further qualitative exploration into the communities, publics, and stakeholders among which organizations act, as well as to more robustly operationalize the concepts of civic listening for measurement, testing, and refinement. Engagement with practitioners, potentially through qualitative interviews, could provide a clearer understanding of how, if at all, the concepts and values of critical civic listening are understood and practiced. In this way, normative theory building for public relations can interact more directly with the realities of praxis.

5. Conclusions

The furthering of normative public relations theory, such as has been our intent herein, often raises the question of how such theory can be applied in practice. Other normative theories, such as dialogue (Kent & Taylor, 2002), fully functioning society (Heath, 2006), and works on organizational activism (i.e. Holtzhausen, 2013) have, by their authors' own admission, been difficult to enact in practice. That said, the concepts addressed here, while indeed normative and aspirational, are not without practical merit or professional feasibility. Organizational listening presents a useful bridge between societal-scale theories and professional public relations work precisely because of its applied, practical nature.

First, civic-minded organizational listening urges the public relations function and individual practitioners to view their work as stewards of discourse (Capizzo, 2018; Heath et al., 2013), champions of pluralism, and internal activists pushing back against those shutting the door on underrepresented voices (Holtzhausen, 2013; Lee, 2021; McCown, 2007). Within the contexts of bracketing and organizational listening,

Arendt's intervention points toward a default organizational stance of active, conscious engagement. In Arnett's (2013) synthesis of Arendt's work, he posited that "a reflective life is our only hope of freedom and our best shot at change as we meet an existence that calls forth responsibility in response to that which we would not expect or desire" (p. 263). Public relations offers the possibilities of reflection for individual practitioners to understand the implications of their actions, as well as to help organizations collectively reflect on their responsibilities to societies and communities. Processes of environmental scanning and representation of alternative views to the so-called dominant coalition of organizations (often done to overcome organizational blindspots or disrupt groupthink) are expected in public relations best practices (e.g., Grunig, 2006). Moreover, conscious and proactive organizational engagement on pressing social issues and taking contested organizational stances are more and more common in contemporary practice (Capizzo, 2020; Williams & Sommerfeldt, 2021) and Arendt's philosophy only adds additional theoretical and social rationales to such behaviors.

Second, with its discourse stewardship responsibilities for organizations (e.g., Capizzo, 2018; Heath et al., 2013), the public relations function is capable of managing and contributing to transparency, authenticity, and honesty that builds trust among community members. As Arnett (2013) notes, "lamp holders give us hope in existence—not false optimism but rather tenacious hope and courage" (p. 118). Helping organizations find and share these truths, even in challenging and contentious circumstances, contributes to civil society. Understanding the power-laden choices of bracketing and unbracketing gives practitioners additional tools with which to make their work more representative of the communities beyond their organizations, and to provide public voice to those most in need of it (Weder, 2021). They support more equitable deliberative contributions through the public relations function (Edwards, 2016). Such mindsets help practitioners understand their role in helping organizations contribute to fully functioning societies (Heath, 2006) and cultivate the communicative bonds of civil society (Sommerfeldt, 2013a; Taylor, 2010).

Public relations has the potential to build conscious, reflective points of connection among civic-minded organizations and individuals. Reflective practices (Holmström, 2005, 2018), intersectional understanding of communities (Place, 2022; Vardeman-Winter & Tindall, 2010), and the prioritization of co-creational communication (Botan, 1997), creates a lens for public relations practice that empowers practitioners to listen and speak with care and ecological perspective. In these ways practitioners can aspire to rebuild societal trust through genuine listening, cultivation of civic and discursive spaces, and reflective, deliberative engagement with the worlds beyond their organizational walls. This work, central to the practice and research of public relations, is important for the long-term maintenance of civil societies, but we believe Arendt would also find it urgent, as encroachment on democratic norms around the world makes the valuing of individual plurality, the safety of interspaces, and the guidance of lamp holders imperative.

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None.

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